

SIERRA NEVADA

California's snowy backbone

At around 4 million years old, the Sierra Nevada is a relatively young range of mountains, forming a dramatic crest 400 miles (650 km) long by 60 miles (100 km) wide along California's eastern edge. At the southern end lies Mount Whitney, the highest US peak outside Alaska at 14,505 ft (4,421 m). The region also boasts the largest alpine lake in North America—the famously clear Lake Tahoe—and three national parks: Yosemite, Sequoia, and Kings Canyon.

Forest and climate zones

The Sierra Nevada's western foothills are cloaked in savanna and deciduous oak woodland, but the rest of the range rising toward the east is dominated by coniferous forest, starting with juniper and Ponderosa and Jeffrey pines at lower altitudes. Giant sequoias start to appear at about 3,280 ft (1,000 m), and higher still, the forests are

dominated by lodgepole pines, red and white fir, and eventually, whitebark pine. Finally, the trees give way to hardy alpine plants at about 10,500 ft (3,200 m). The forests are interspersed with rivers and lakes, wet and dry meadows, and extensive areas of brushland.

The wide range of altitudes and climates in the Sierra Nevada is reflected in the diverse wildlife. Animals living at higher altitudes, such as alpine chipmunks and pikas, must be able to tolerate low temperatures and snow for much of the year. The mountains are also home to both black and brown bears, bald eagles, and increasing numbers of American beavers.



BLACK-BACKED WOODPECKER

BURNED FOREST
Black-backed woodpeckers exploit the aftermath of a fire, rapidly colonizing areas where dead wood teems with beetle grubs. As the area regenerates and beetle numbers decline, the birds gradually move on.

PREDATOR IN DECLINE
Once widespread, this key forest predator has declined due to trapping. Despite protection, fisher numbers in the Sierra Nevada remain worryingly low. Their loss from the ecosystem would affect the natural balance between predators and prey.



FISHER

SUPERFOOD BONANZA
Sierra Nevada's rivers are important spawning grounds for Chinook salmon, and their spring breeding run provides a feeding bonanza for bears and other predators. However, overexploitation of the region's water resources threatens the species.

CHINOOK SALMON

Has North

Home to the giant sequoia General Sherman, the second largest living thing